



△ Patiala necklace in its restored state

Maharaja's Patiala necklace

The Patiala necklace was a spectacular, five-tiered Art-Deco diamond necklace, which incorporated the famous De Beers diamond and was made for India's Maharaja of Patiala, Bhupinder Singh, by Cartier in 1928. It later disappeared for a time, but was rediscovered and restored.

The necklace's platinum base contained 2,930 diamonds, weighing a collective 962.25 carats. The world's seventh-largest diamond, the light yellow "De Beers", formed its centrepiece at 234.65 carats. Other highlights included two Burmese rubies and an 18-carat tobacco-coloured diamond, one of the necklace's seven large diamonds ranging from 18 to 73 carats.

Yadavindra Singh inherited the necklace with his father's title in 1938. However, the Indian state came under financial pressure and was forced to sell off several of the necklace's stones. Its platinum base later



Watch with a portrait of Bhupinder Singh, c.1930

vanished from the royal treasury – presumably also sold – after India achieved independence in 1947. In 1998, the greatly diminished necklace resurfaced in a London antiques shop, where a Cartier representative recognized and purchased it. The largest of its stones were missing, including the famous De Beers diamond.

Cartier set about restoring the necklace, initially replacing missing diamonds with other natural stones such as white and yellow sapphires, white topaz, and garnets. However, these lacked the same brilliant effect as diamonds. The jewellers opted for a dazzling array of white cubic zirconias and other synthetic diamonds, as well as synthetic topaz, ruby, smoky quartz, and citrine stones.

In 2002, Cartier displayed the necklace in its New York boutique, attracting crowds of onlookers. Even without all of its original huge and valuable gems, the necklace was still a dazzling sight.



Bhupinder Singh's silver-gilt dinner service, made for a visit by future king Edward VIII in 1922

A wonder of natural beauty and supreme craftsmanship

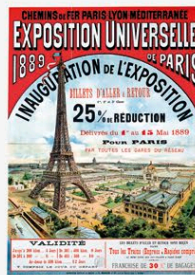
Richard **Dorment**
Art critic

Key dates

1888–present

1888 The De Beers diamond is discovered in a South African De Beers mine

1889 The diamond is cut and displayed in Paris at the Exposition Universelle. Rajendra Singh, Maharaja of Patiala, purchases it



Poster for the Exposition Universelle of 1889



The De Beers diamond

1925 Bhupinder Singh visits Cartier in Paris with the De Beers diamond and numerous other unset stones to commission a necklace – Cartier's largest ever commission

1928 Cartier completes the necklace and exhibits it before it is sent to India

1947 The necklace disappears after several stones, including the De Beers, are sold separately

1998 Eric Nussbaum, a Swiss born gemologist working with Cartier, discovers the necklace in a London antique shop

2002–present Cartier exhibits the restored necklace internationally

1982 The De Beers diamond reappears at auction by Sotheby's in Geneva, where it sells for below the asking price

2000

2015